A Hand for Peace

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31372154.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Historical, Alternate Universe - Medieval, Best Friends, Friends to Lovers, Arranged Marriage, Magic, War, Royalty, Angst, POV Third Person

Language:
English

Collections:
Glimbow Week (2021)

Stats:
Published: 2021-05-18 Words: 3,410 Chapters: 2/2

A Hand for Peace

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31372154.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Historical, Alternate Universe - Medieval, Best Friends, Friends to Lovers, Arranged Marriage, Magic, War, Royalty, Angst, POV Third Person

Language:
English

Collections:
Glimbow Week (2021)

Stats:
Published: 2021-05-18 Words: 3,410 Chapters: 2/2

A Hand for Peace

by fortunavitae

Summary

SPOP Medieval AU. The Horde Empire is threatening to invade the Kingdom of Bright Moon, and the only way to prevent war is through nuptials... However, neither Princess Glimmer nor Sir Bowden are very keen of that solution.

Notes

For Glimbow Week Spring 21, Day 4: What if?

In this AU, I tried to reimagine what would have happened if Etheria had a more rigid royalty system; one similar to our world. The rest; the magic, the universal respect to gender identities, etc. are mostly the same as in the show.

Also, Glimmer is canonically bi, right? Because uhh, even if she is not, she is so here..

Princess Glimmer

"Princess, Her Excellency the Queen requests your presence at her private quarters."

The guard looked so blissfully ignorant of why the princess was summoned. But Glimmer knew, and she wasn't exactly thrilled to have this conversation with her mother.

She dismissed the guard with a nod and closed the door behind him. The Queen hated to wait, but Glimmer needed a second by herself before facing her destiny.

She paced her room with heavy steps, her hands crossed behind her.

Glimmer had always known that being a royal wasn't only glitz and glamour, and that there was much pain and hardship hiding under the bejewelled Crown. It had cost her so much already: her childhood, her father, her freedom… and yet, she would not complain. No, she loved Bright Moon and Etheria with all her heart, and she would do anything for her kingdom. If it came to that, Glimmer knew that she would die for Bright Moon, and rightfully so. Afterall, she was strong, she was brave.

But she didn't know how she would do what her mother was about to ask from her.

She took a deep breath. Avoidance was futile. Sooner or later, she would need to comply and fulfil her duty.

She straightened her back, pulled down her dress, tried to erase all emotion off her face, and left her room.

The castle was damp and cold. It always was so in autumn. The rain would seep through the giant stone blocks of the Bright Moon castle, bringing a mossy smell along. The long purple train

sweeping behind her was already heavy with the smut on the floor. She kept walking anyway. She could have teleported, but she dreaded this talk so much that she would do anything to delay it — including walking. Nonetheless, her quarters were in the same wing as her mother's, so soon enough, she stood in front of the giant door guarded by two soldiers. They pulled aside at her sight.

"Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon, Your Excellency."

Glimmer was still amused by the guards announcing her full title to her mother, the Queen. As if there was any other Princess Glimmer in the whole realm other than the one of Bright Moon. Sometimes she so hated all these formalities surrounding her life. She wished to be able to walk up to her mother, to casually hug her, or be able to talk back to her like many young women her age could. But of course, those were not luxuries that the Princess of Bright Moon possessed.

"Daughter, come on in."

The doors closed behind her. The Queen sat at the tea table set by the window. She seemed tired, perturbed. She rarely let her emotions surface, and seeing her so clearly uncomfortable bothered Glimmer. But as soon as she heard her daughter come in, she quickly switched back to her signature serene but stone cold face. She gestured Glimmer to sit.

"Daughter, as my heir, one day you will take over this realm. One day, you shall be the ruler of the kingdom of Bright Moon."

Glimmer nodded, unimpressed with this restatement of facts. Couldn't she just get done with it already?

"And as the future Queen, you have a duty towards your subjects. Your people look up to you for their well-being, their survival."

Way to darken the mood, mother, she thought to herself.

Queen Angella raised her hand, and a maid appeared behind her, holding what seemed to be a canvas wrapped in cotton fabric. The Queen held the painting, and unveiled the portrait of a young man in black and grey ceremonial garments.

"What do you think of him?"

What did Glimmer think of him? Glimmer thought that he was a pig, a prick, a scoundrel, a miscreant with no heart. Of course, in his painting, he was unassuming of any title other than that of a prince, but Glimmer knew about his father's armies amassing at the Bright Moon borders, so it wasn't hard to reach to that conclusion.

The Queen turned the painting at herself, observing the young man for her own. She broke an awry smile.

"Come on, he is quite handsome."

Glimmer clenched her fists on her lap, barely keeping her impertinent comments to herself.

Angella was perceptive though. She saw through her daughter, and placed her hand on Glimmer's.

"Look, you don't have to marry him."

Her voice was soft and caring, so un-queenly.

"I would hate to see you unhappy." she added, in the same caring tone. But Glimmer knew that this did not mean that she could do whatever she wanted. Her mother was setting up an illusion, attempting to make Glimmer think that she actually had a choice, while everyone knew that she had none.

"All I ask you to do is to give him a chance."

Ah, there they were. The Queen's true intentions.

“Maybe he is not as bad as…” Angella could not finish her sentence. She swallowed the rest of her words along with some air.

Glimmer nodded. “It’s alright mother. Even if he is, I understand that this is my duty…”

That was what royals would marry for. Not for love. Sometimes for money. But usually for power. In Glimmer’s case, it would be for peace, which was probably better than the other two.

“Daughter, you do not have to marry him if you don’t want to. But Emperor Hordak has made his intention clear. You must at least seem to consider it. If we were to flat out reject his son, we would attract the Horde Empire’s wrath. And I do not know if our kingdom could withstand that.”

Glimmer could not help but let out a cynical laugh. “Ah, yes mother. Of course. As if Emperor Horse-Dung would accept *any* kind rejection!”

Angella opened her mouth, shocked of her daughter’s behaviour, but not too much. After all, she knew Glimmer and her habit of saying things with little reservation. Of course, that did not mean that she condoned it.

But seriously, what did her mother think? That if Glimmer allowed his son to court her for a while then gently let him down, Emperor Hordak would be fine with it? No, he would march his armies to Bright Moon anyway.

“Glimmer.” The Queen wrapped both her hands around Glimmer’s. Pink sparkles were escaping between her fingers. Glimmer so wished that she had a more useful gift than whatever shiny power she had. Something intimidating. Something like shooting lightnings out of her fingers or whispering to snakes. Those would have been more fitting to Glimmer’s character. Also, maybe then she could infiltrate Hordak’s palace and blow him and his son up to his pieces. But no, all she had was pink light balls and an ability

to teleport which was way too weak to materialise in Hordak's palace and killing him on the spot.

"Glimmer, I am serious. You don't have to marry him. I was lucky enough to marry your late father for love, and I cannot forbid the same to my own daughter."

That was true. Glimmer had known little about her father, but the King and Queen's love story was an epic told through the seven realms.

However, Glimmer knew that she would not be that lucky. She could not possibly risk the future of her kingdom to marry for love. She ran her gaze away from her mother's, looking up the blue skies and the birds soaring through the wind.

"Glimmer. I *will not* let Hordak to bully me into giving you away." Angella sounded so stern, so decided. And yet, Glimmer knew that her mother was making herself believe a lie. Even the mighty Angel Queen could not stand the Horde Empire all by herself.

The Princess of Bright Moon pulled her hands out of her mother's and rose. She turned to the maid.

"Let Prince Priam of Horde know that I will accept him as my guest to Bright Moon."

Angella seemed defeated, devasted even, as if she hadn't known how this conversation would end from the beginning. She laid back into her couch, putting her hand over her temples, seemingly prey to a sudden headache. She was not one to dramatize, but Glimmer knew that her mother hated this situation nearly as much as her. Too bad, because whether the Queen like it or not, this was happening.

Glimmer did not wait to be excused. There was nothing left to say, and she did not want her mother to see her in a moment of weakness. Now that the Queen was breaking, at least one of

them had to be strong. She managed to keep her determined, ice cold posture until she left the room, but as soon as she was in the corridor, tears started to stream down her cheeks. She teleported away to materialise somewhere, anywhere away from her mother.

Sir Bowden

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Sir Bowden, Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon, Her Highness sent this note for you."

Bow let loose the arrow he held between his fingertips. Despite the diversion, the arrow hit straight the bullseye on the training dummy that stood on top of the tall walls surrounding the castle. He laid down his bow, and took the note out of the maid's hands.

This was strange. Glimmer would never send him notes. She would simply appear wherever he was. He had no idea how, but she always managed to guess perfectly where he was. He instinctively looked behind his shoulder, expecting to see her glittery silhouette. But Glimmer did not come.

He had grown accustomed to the Princess of Bright Moon materialising next to him ever since he was a little page. This very much irked her governess and his Knight master, especially when Glimmer would skip a lesson to crash one of Bow's, but the Queen seemed to approve of their friendship, so little anyone could complain.

Bow inspected the little lilac envelop with a pearly shine. The royal stationary was elegant, noble. That, until Bow opened the envelop and unveiled the note written in haphazard lines with little care of legibility.

"The gardens. Tonight."

Bow could barely wait for the nightfall. Glimmer was the most impulsive and impatient person he knew. Also, she had little to no filter when it came to sharing with him, so when something

happened to her, he would always be the first (and usually only) one to learn about it. As such, he could not help but wonder what was so exceptional that she would feel the need to set up a rendezvous.

At first he was simply curious, but as the sun disappeared behind the hills that surrounded Bright Moon, he started to worry. If Glimmer had managed to not tell him what was happening immediately, it had to be bad news that she was dreading to deliver to him. He wanted to keep his spirits up, but he knew that if it were something good, Glimmer would have cracked and teleported next to him to spill the beans already.

He took a deep breath and turned his gaze to the starry sky. As if she wanted to startle him, Glimmer chose the exact moment to materialise just behind him. Bow smiled instinctively when he heard the magical chiming announcing Glimmer's arrival.

"Bow."

That was what she called him. Sure, his knight title was Sir Bowden and everybody called him that; but not Glimmer. And to be honest, he liked Bow better too. For him, the real Bowden men were his fathers, men of science who pursued wisdom through knowledge, and that was not him. He was not a Bowden scholar. He was Bow the Knight, who was a master of the weapon of which he took the name.

"Glimmer? Is everything alright?"

Again, anyone who called the Princess of Bright Moon by her name only would normally be banished. But Glimmer hate of titles was universal; so, to please her while keeping his job, Bow would call her by her first name when they were alone. Although, he doubted that she would have cared even if he called her "Your Highness" at this point. She seemed so focused, so serious.

"No. Nothing's alright."

She grabbed his wrist, and in a second, they were gone. When they reappeared, Bow thought at first that his dizziness was due to the teleportation. But as the cloud of sparkles before his eyes dispersed and the bubbly feeling wore off, his head kept spinning. When he looked down, he realised that they were on top of the castle's tallest tower. Sensing that he might lose his balance, Glimmer hung onto his arm, and protectively pulling him close to herself.

"I am sorry," she said, "I needed to talk to you privately." She raised her head in an attempt to look at him, but then quickly ran her gaze away. Ok, seriously, what was going on? This was so unseemly of Glimmer.

Bow reached out for her hands, his palms pressing against the inside of her wrists. She was ice cold, but somehow sweaty too.

He sat on the bare stone and gently pulled Glimmer down to his side. "Don't apologise." he said. "What's going on?"

Her face was washed up by the night light. The moon was barely a crescent tonight, but a soft beam fell directly onto Glimmer's face as if it had chosen to bless her. She stood for a second, her gaze running across the horizon. Her lips were pressed against each other, tormented on whether to let out the words.

Finally she gave in. Eyes still stuck on the dark horizon, she spoke.

"Mother wants me to marry Prince Priam to ease the Horde."

She managed to keep her posture, but she could not withhold it for more than a second. Like a broken mask, her cold stone face dropped and tears erupted under. She hid behind her hands.

Bow wrapped his arm around her, pulling her in. He felt her sobs in his chest, which made them tenfold more painful.

Glimmer was to get married? And to Prince Priam. Priam the Cunning. He had gotten this name for he was leading his father's armies to conquest, and word was that he was an extraordinary

strategist. As clever as he could be, Bow did not doubt that he was a terrible person. He would usually give people the benefit of doubt, but Prince Priam's reputation preceded him. Besides, he wanted to marry Glimmer. And for what? To get a hold over Bright Moon. Bow did not even want to try and empathise. He hated him already.

"There must be another way." mumbled he.

Glimmer snuffled and attempted to tame her tears. She wiped her eyes to the long cuffs of her dress. She pulled her head out of Bow's embrace, and raised it straight, like the noblewoman she was.

"There isn't. If I don't marry him, Hordak will invade Bright Moon."

Bow turned to her, now in his turn slipping into his role as a warrior.

"Then we fight." stated he. His voice was strong, commandeering. He could not allow that. He could not stand and watch Glimmer get married to Prince Priam.

Bow had always known that this day would eventually come. Eventually, a prince or a princess would show up, woo Glimmer with their royal charms, and steal her away from him. And he would be lucky if he continued being Glimmer's best friend after that. After all, how could he compete with a royal partner? He was just a knight who had sworn to protect the crown. And he was lucky to have received the princess' friendship and affection to begin with.

He had made peace with that, or so he thought. All he knew was that he would have to give up Glimmer eventually. But to Prince Priam, out of all the royalty in Etheria? That was insult just to injury. He could not let this happen. Glimmer deserved to marry someone who would make her happy, someone she loved. Not a prick, no, *the* prick from the Horde Empire.

“We can’t fight.” said Glimmer. She sounded so decisive, yet so defeated. “I cannot start a war just to marry for true love.”

Then, she let out a cynical laugh. It might have irked other people, but Bow somehow liked this side of Glimmer. She would not shy away from speaking her mind and feelings at any instance, which was very brave for someone of her status.

“It’s like not like I have a true love to get married to either!” she exclaimed, raising her hands in protest. Her laughter quickly melt into a sulk.

Her comment sunk deep into Bow’s heart. If he were an impulsive person, he could have let his unresolved feelings surface at this moment, but that was not him. Glimmer had more than enough to deal with, and he simply could not further burden her with his own confusion. So he bit his tongue, and forced himself to lie.

“You will. One day, you will find that prince or princess.”

Glimmer took his hand between hers and threw her head back. As she observed the stars, Bow observed her. The moonlight was certainly favouring her, because he could not otherwise explain how she could shine so beautifully in the dark, like a pearl in deep waters. She radiated with warmth, her eyes running between the stars, certainly imagining that perfect royal she ought to fall in love with.

She glared at him, before turning back to the stars.

“Maybe I’d marry a knight.” claimed she, playfully. The moonlight betrayed her blushing cheeks.

Bow felt his head warming up like a blacksmith’s furnace. A weird feeling appeared in his stomach, and a warm shiver took over his body. But before he could process what she said, Glimmer continued talking, now discouraged beyond belief.

“Not that it would ever happen.” She let go of his hand, detached her gaze from the stars, and started watching the dark courtyard

laying beneath them instead.

“Why not?” Bow could not believe that he had let this question escape his mind.

“Because, I am to marry the stupid prince!” She shrugged with frustration, shaking her fists in the air. Pink sparkles flew around like fireflies and one disappeared just before Bow’s nose. And just like that, he had an idea.

He excitedly grabbed her hand once more. “Say, Glimmer? What if there were an alliance between the seven realms? The Horde Empire could not fight all seven of them at the same time.” It was true. Hordak could be strong, but he would not be able to fend off all seven kingdoms at once.

Glimmer looked at their locked hands thoughtfully. Her thumb slid up and down the top of his hand, striking some mellowing chords in his heart.

“Bow, that’s a very nice thought, but the seven kingdoms haven’t gotten along in such a long time. Hell, we would have been in war with some if we all weren’t terrified of the Horde.”

She picked up a small piece of rock off the floor, and threw it into the dark courtyard. It was like she had given up all hope already. But Bow did not want to go without a fight. He had to make sure that Glimmer would not need to throw her life away to keep Bright Moon safe.

“Well,” he mused, “What if the Princess of Bright Moon visited the other princes and princesses to get their opinion on this? Maybe the heirs would be more open to negotiation?” A grin appeared on his face. See? He could be cunning too! Take that Prince Priam!

Glimmer threw him a mischievous look, which was quickly overpowered by doubt. “Do you think it would work?..”

He threw his arm around her shoulders and pulled her in. “Well, do we have another choice than to try?” asked he. His gentle eyes

locked to hers and he broke a melancholic but somewhat hopeful smile.

The Princess of Bright Moon was finally convinced. “I guess not…” she said, leaning against his chest, her breaths slowing down.

Bow put his head above hers, finding comfort in the softness of her hair.

So be it, he thought to himself. If he had to make peace between the seven realms so that Glimmer would not marry someone she did not love, that was exactly what he was going to do.

Chapter End Notes

I could not help but make a (double) pun again in the title...

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!